



REPORT

Harden UAC via Local Group Policy

v1.0.0

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REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	 Author	Description of Changes
v1.0.0	09/22/2025	Eldon G.	Initial draft.





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SECTION 1.0: HARDENING USER ACCOUNT CONTROL (UAC)

1.1 Project Overview

The objective of this project was to harden User Account Control (UAC) settings on a Windows 10 machine to mitigate risks such as unauthorized privilege escalation, credential spoofing, and malware installation without user approval. By enforcing explicit credential prompts and secure desktop elevation, the machine's security posture was significantly improved.



Disclaimer: This report documents my personal work completing an MCSI lab exercise. It reflects my understanding and configuration of Windows 10 UAC settings in a controlled, offline environment. No MCSI video or lab materials have been posted, shared, or distributed, ensuring compliance with MCSI's policies.



1.2 Technical Configuration Steps

The hardening configuration focused on three main UAC control areas:

- **Administrator Behavior** – Enabling approval requirements for the built-in administrator account.
- **Elevation Prompts** – Requiring explicit credential input for both standard and administrative users.
- **Secure Desktop Enforcement** – Mandating the use of the secure desktop for all elevation prompts to mitigate spoofing risks.

This approach improved resilience against privilege escalation by ensuring that all elevation requests were tightly controlled and visibly separated from the user's normal desktop environment.

1.3 Validation Steps

- Launched an application requiring administrative privileges.
 - A verified credential prompt appeared on the **secure desktop**, confirming that the hardened UAC policies were active.
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1.4 Observations / Troubleshooting

- After enabling Admin Approval Mode, elevation prompts were consistently credential-based instead of a simple “Yes/No” confirmation.
- No compatibility issues arose with applications tested; for example, **Microsoft Edge** and **Notepad++** ran without interruption under the hardened UAC settings.

1.5 Supporting Work

Documented the hierarchical policy paths within the Local Group Policy Editor to ensure that the configuration process could be repeated consistently in future environments.





SECTION 2.0: CONCLUSION

2.1 Key Takeaways

- The hardening of UAC enforces credential-based authentication for sensitive actions.
- Secure desktop elevation reduces the risks of spoofing and phishing attacks.
- Group Policy provides a repeatable and centralized method for enforcing user access control.

2.2 Security Implications and Recommendations

- Hardened UAC reduces the opportunities for attackers to escalate privileges.
 - Credential-based prompts ensure the accountability and traceability of sensitive actions.
 - In business settings, these rules should be used with other measures such as logging, monitoring, and providing the least access needed for full protection.
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